

Ch 1 – Shifting Sands

David blinked, clawing his way back up from the relative peace he had been drifting in, Or... he thought he did. It was hard to tell. Everything was dark, dry, and close, the grit scratching faintly against his eyelashes the only real proof his eyes were open at all.

He tried to swallow.

Instant regret. His throat seized on the attempt, dragged across a thick film of silt and dust that coated his mouth like wet plaster. The cough that followed didn't come from his chest — it *wrung* him from the inside out, deep and rolling and loud in the otherwise perfect silence.

Pain bloomed through his right shoulder like someone'd lit a flare inside the joint. Not enough to knock him out again — even if for a moment, his body strongly considered it — but enough to burn through the fog at the edge of his thoughts.

That arm... where even was it?

He shifted, or tried to. The shoulder was wrenched backward at an unnatural angle, trapped somewhere behind him. He couldn't quite feel it. Not properly. Given the position, it was probably underneath him, and had been for quite some time.

How long had he even been out?

The air tasted stale. Not rot-stale, just... *old*. Like it had already been breathed once and politely declined a second use. It clung to the grit in his throat, and for a moment, he couldn't tell if that was the room's fault or his own.

He tried to roll just enough to shift the pressure off the dead arm.

No luck.

Something sharp greeted him in every direction — jagged ribs of rubble mixed with the broader flat crush of stone slabs. They pressed in at odd angles, some stabbing through cloth to find skin, others just... *there*, forcing joints into unnatural postures and denying leverage entirely.

The ground beneath him was cool and unmoving, a layer of compacted sand that offered no give and even less comfort.

His left arm, at least, was mostly free. Curled near his head, though the space was tight enough he had to move slow just to avoid flaying himself against unseen edges.

Fingers crept outward, brushing along the nearby debris.

Rough, gritty surfaces met his touch — stone fractured under pressure, shedding streams of dry sand that whispered down onto his face in response.

He stilled.

Sand?

...Oh. Right.

The walkway. The Eyrie.

He remembered the brittle stretch of stone underfoot — just wide enough to make him run stupid, just thin enough to make him regret it.

Nemesis had swung at him; he remembered *that* much. A wide, angry arc meant for bone, not structure.

It hit a support pillar instead.

The whole thing had come down like it was made of plaster and drywall, not ancient stone.

He didn't remember the fall itself — just the sound.

The crack of crumbling masonry.

A sharp impact.

Then darkness.

In hindsight, it must've taken more than just the walkway. Probably part of the stairwell too.

There was *way* too much debris around him for this to be a single platform collapse.

This was an **avalanche**. Bad maintenance and worse luck, stacked like bricks and now buried in his ribs.

Funny thing was... the landing hadn't even hurt. Not really. He'd hit the ground so hard, there hadn't been time for pain. Just an impact. Then lights out.

Waking up though?

That was a different story.

His head throbbed, low and deep and constant. Not sharp — just heavy, like the ache had weight. It pressed against the background noise of every other random pain that was gradually waking up and won the argument.

Miraculously, his skull had held. No blood in his eyes. No dripping sounds. No open gash.

Just a single jagged stone pressed against his temple, insistent and quiet.

Not hard enough to break skin. But close.

If he'd fallen just slightly to the left...

His skull wouldn't have stopped the blow.

It would've caved. Like an egg.

Hell of a mess, that would've made. Bits of him everywhere. Real inconvenience.

He shut that thought down before it went anywhere useful.

He swallowed down another cough, forcing it into silence with sheer will.

The dust still clawed at the back of his throat, but he wasn't about to trigger another body-wide shudder. Not with the rubble that had started treating him like a stress ball.

Alright. Inventory time.

Nothing felt *missing*. That was a start.

His legs were there. Chest still intact, more or less.

Bruised? Absolutely.

Bleeding? Probably.

Slightly crushed in places? Almost definitely.

But still whole.

The right arm though...

He tried to flex the fingers. Nothing. No twitch. No sting. No pull in the tendons.

There was just... *absence*. A hollow space where the arm should've existed in his mind.

It wasn't pain that unsettled him — it was the *lack* of it.

That meant the limb had been pinned long enough to kill sensation.

Great. That was gonna be a fun reintroduction once the nerves decided to clock back in.

He couldn't even tell if it was broken or just numb.

Either way...

Problem for later.

He shifted his left arm carefully, slow enough to avoid brushing any sharp edges. The motion dragged across stone — rough, uneven — and he curled it inward, trying to map his own torso through the press of rubble.

Chest. Side. Hip.

Rubble. More rubble. A jagged piece jutting near his ribs.

Everything was compact. Tight. Smothered.

But not entirely immobile.

Each movement sent a faint shiver through the pile.

He could feel it above him — stones shifting, not much, but *not nothing*.

Grains of sand trickled down the back of his neck. A whisper of weight.

Somewhere near his shoulder, a chunk of debris let out a gritty sigh and resettled. Just a little.

The silence around him made it unbearable.

It wasn't dramatic. Nothing tumbled. Nothing cracked.

But the rubble remembered it could move.

And every breath he took was a nudge toward that decision.

His elbow shifted back, catching the edge of a stone lightly.

Something above him *moved*.

The weight across his torso dipped, then ground slightly sideways, a low, gravelly slide that pressed new pain into his legs and kicked up another burst of dust.

He froze.

A larger block near his head scraped down half an inch with a lazy, predatory shrug.

Instinct took over before thought could catch up — his left arm snapped upward, wedging between the stone and his face. Not to shove it back — he didn't have that kind of leverage — but just to *catch* it. Slow it. Redirect it.

If it came down further, it was going to hit something.

Better the arm than the eye.

The last dust stirred loose by the shift hit his lungs like sandpaper.

He choked, sharp and sudden, and the cough tore through his body before he could stop it.

Stone dug deeper into his side as his ribs convulsed, and a fresh spray of pebbles tumbled down his collarbone — dry, biting, unkind.

Above him, the ceiling of stone responded.

It shifted again.

Just once.

Then — mercifully — it stopped.

His chest heaved, but he forced it smaller. Slower.

Every breath was an act of balance now.

Too deep, and the rubble pressed down.

Too shallow, and he'd choke on the dust still clinging to his throat.

He was awake now. *Fully*.

No more haze. No more drifting thoughts.

Just the weight. The dust. The sound of his own pulse in his ears.

If he moved too much, the whole pile would remember what it was capable of.

Every breath shifted the stones by fractions.

Every shift tempted gravity to finish the job.

The Eyrie hadn't just collapsed.

It had **buried** him.

And all he could do — *the only thing* — was stay very, very still...

...and hope the next person to find him wasn't the seven-foot steroid golem that put him here in the first place.

Ch 2 – Liminal

David didn't know if he'd blacked out again, or if time had just slithered sideways without telling him. There was no sky to track. No light to shift. Just the weight, the ache, and the slow, dry scrape of dust collecting in his lungs with every shallow breath. Random pains seemed to shift or bloom when he hadn't been paying attention.

His right arm was still a blank in his perception. Maybe asleep. Maybe broken. Hard to say. Harder to care. It wasn't coming back online anytime soon either way. His left was another story.

That one still worked, still braced above him, still bearing the load. His forearm wedged between his face and the nearest stone, keeping it from finishing the job. The muscles in his shoulder screamed now — not in bursts, but in a steady, smoldering burn, like fire left to smother under its own ash. A pain too quiet to scream, too loud to ignore.

He hadn't dared move it. Not for... minutes? Hours? He had taken to resting its weight against his forehead, but the pressure of the stones above still kept the muscle tight.

However long it had been, the limb was shaking now. Not much. Just the tiniest tremble.

But in a place like this, *tiny* had teeth.

At some point, he started hearing things. A voice? Maybe. Probably not. Prolonged silence did weird things to a person's mind, and with this headache, it was likely just his own thoughts bouncing off him.

No, that wasn't it... it was more of a yell. Far off. Muffled. Familiar in a way that made his chest seize up for reasons he couldn't quite name. Was that him, or something real?

He held his breath, forcing himself to listen through the roar of his own pulse. There. Something again. Footsteps? The crunch of sand under boots?

Soft voices filtered in through the silence — so faint he almost missed them.

“Why is he chasing her like that?”

“Because it’s Jill. Nemesis sees that uniform and gets tunnel vision. I’d be shocked if he *wasn’t* chasing her.”

“So, then we... what? Just let her get chased?”

“Well yeah. She’ll be ok. We can get things done in the meantime.”

David blinked slowly, grit dragging across his lashes. He hadn’t imagined it.

Someone was out there. Outside the Eyrie. *Getting closer.*

It was surreal. Voices drifting past like it was just another day in the Fog, laughing about killer patterns and survivor bait while he lay crushed in the dark, half-buried under a structure that wanted to finish folding him like a lawn chair.

His sanity creaked under the weight of it.

A small prickle of panic clawed at the back of his throat. He couldn’t tell where the voices were coming from just from the sound alone — whether they were near the Eyrie or just *passing by*. He couldn’t wave. Couldn’t even shift enough to make noise without risking a full cave-in.

But if they didn’t come into the building... if they didn’t see the rubble...

They’d miss him entirely.

He didn’t have the luxury of waiting. He had to try.

He swallowed. The grit in his throat made the motion grind. He tried to shout.

Nothing.

A wheeze. A cough. Pain flared in his ribs as a stone shifted threateningly and jabbed his side.

“Here,” he rasped, a thread of voice scraping out like broken glass.

“Hey—!”

It wasn’t much. Just two syllables and a thread of panic. But they scratched their way through the cracks.

And Dwight stopped walking. Mid-step. Boot still half-hovering over the sand.

“...Wait.”

Felix paused beside him, glancing back. “What is it?”

“I — hold on.” Dwight tilted his head, gaze flicking toward the building. “I thought I heard something.”

Felix didn’t catch it, whatever it was. But Dwight had that look — the one he got right before finding a teammate bleeding out behind a wall no one else thought to check. Felix had been in enough trials by now to know better than to ignore the man’s instincts. He followed him toward the Eyrie’s doors.

Inside, the Eyrie was eerily still. Books. Way too much sand. A lone generator, cold and ignored. And a pile of rubble where half of a staircase used to be.

“Looks like the walkway above collapsed,” Felix murmured, eyes tracing the damage. “Took part of the stairwell with it. I wasn’t even aware the landscape *could* collapse like that in a trial.”

“Things have been weird lately. Who knows what’s possible anymore.”

The Eyrie had always been a weird mix of hideous planning and impressive masonry. Still, this was new. He caught himself studying the fault lines, noting where the arch had folded under its own weight — a perfect storm of tension and force — when Dwight’s voice cut through his thoughts, reminding him why they were there.

“Hello?”

A sound broke the quiet. Small. Choked. Like someone trying to stifle a cough.

Felix froze mid-step, spine straightening instinctively.

“Okay. That I heard.”

Dwight was already turning toward the rubble, expression sharpening. It was an odd place to hunker down. Too exposed, no clear escape route. Although, if Jill was outside running Nemesis in circles, and he and Felix were right there...

“David?” he called out, tone tight.

"I'm here," came the thin reply — warped by grit and pressure, but unmistakably human. "Could use a hand, tho."

Felix's head snapped toward the rubble, alarm flickering beneath his usual calm.

"Did that just come from *inside* the collapse?"

"Wait—shit," Dwight surged forward without waiting for confirmation, boots kicking up sand. "Are you okay?! What happened?"

No reply at first. Just the dull sound of stone shifting as David let his head rest against his arm again — too drained to move, too relieved not to. His body shook once, tension flaring and failing all at once.

"Just get me out of here," he muttered. "*Carefully*. This shit is held together by spite."

Dwight and Felix traded a glance — silent, serious — before dropping to assess the pile.

"We've got you," Dwight said, already brushing grit away with careful hands and moving to grip at the stones. "Just stay with us."

David barely exhaled. A thread of breath. A flicker of disbelief. Help had come.

Now all they had to do... was not kill him with it.

Chapter 3 – Breakpoint

The digging inevitably slowed after a time.

Not because they were tiring — but because the pile was starting to respond.

Felix had been directing the work with surgical precision, calling out load-bearing stones and picking targets with care, but even then... progress was agonizingly slow. Dwight's idle chatter had kept David distracted for a while, the relief of not being alone having given him something else to focus on, but it did little to disguise the feeling of weight shifting as they worked. Every piece of rubble shifted something. Each stone removed sent new tremors through the makeshift tomb, and David felt it everywhere.

The weight on his chest didn't ease. If anything, it pressed in harder, like the structure above was getting impatient. Every time he exhaled, the space around his ribs compressed a little more. Tiny, incremental shifts. No sudden movements. Just the slow, inevitable collapse of geometry.

Felix called something from above — an update, maybe. Dwight's voice replied, closer now, strained and anxious. David couldn't make out the words. All he could hear was stone — the subtle grind of weight against weight. The whisper of pressure shifting in search of somewhere else to land. His right shoulder had started to burn. The numb, heavy blankness of his pinned arm was waking up again — coming back to him in flashes of static pain.

Each inhale was a losing battle. Each exhale left him less to work with. The air that left his lungs didn't come back — not fully. The space around him shrank by fractions, inch by inch, until it felt like the rubble was learning to breathe with him. Like a snake coiling tighter with every motion, the stones above stole space his body couldn't reclaim.

The panic didn't crash down all at once. It seeped in quiet at the edges, crawling like cold fingers along the base of his skull. He pushed it back as best he could every time it flared up, but it kept coming back.

He could feel the pile sliding. Not the big rocks. Not yet. Just the little ones. Pebbles crawling over his arm. Grit dusting down into the hollows of his collarbone. Something sharp shifted under his ribs — he couldn't tell if it was a rock or a cracked bone.

The dust thickened, burning his eyes, clawing its way down his throat. He coughed again, this one violent enough to spike fresh pain through his chest.

Still, he stayed quiet. The words wanted out. He locked them behind his teeth.

"...getting close," Dwight cut through from above. "I think I see his shoulder — yeah, that's fabric. That's him."

"Careful," Felix warned. "Don't pull — just clear around it."

David tried to nod. Couldn't. The pressure was too tight. "You're doing fine. Just... don't stop."

There was a tremble in his voice he couldn't quite hide.

"David?" Dwight's voice lowered. "You okay?"

He grunted. “Still here.” Technically true.

It didn’t matter that he couldn’t draw a full breath anymore.

Didn’t matter that every muscle left was burning just trying to hold his arm up between his skull and the stone.

If he told them it was getting worse, they’d panic.

If they panicked, they’d rush.

If they rushed, they’d make a mistake.

“I’m fine. Just shut up and dig.”

Each exhale cost him ground he couldn’t take back. Chest sinking shallower. Lungs compressing further with every ragged breath. The edges of his vision sparked, dust and shadows closing in like a tunnel he couldn’t claw out of.

A narrow small gap opened as a stone was pulled away. Just large enough for Dwight to push his arm through. David flinched as fingers found his, wrapping around the hand still braced against the weight.

“You’re doing good,” Dwight said gently, voice tight but even. “Just keep talking to me. We’ve got you. You’re gonna be okay.”

David clenched his jaw, willing himself not to panic. He focused on the contact. Not the dust. Not the stone. Not the crush of air that wouldn’t come back in. It wasn’t much. But it was the closest to *outside* he’d been in over an hour.

“You better be right,” he rasped. “Don’t suppose you found a crowbar down here with me?”

That got a light chuckle from Dwight, the soft sound easing back some of the anxiety. This was good. They had opened up some space. Let in some light. Just that much closer to getting back into the open air again. He could handle this. It was hardly the worst trial he had gone through, anyways.

“Alright,” Felix called. “Top layer’s mostly clear on this side. I can see the shape of him — his shoulder’s wedged under that flat slab. If we shift it straight up and back—”

CRACK.

It wasn’t a collapse. Just a single, fist-sized chunk of sandstone coming loose from somewhere higher up.

But it landed square on the pile, driving a lower stone into David's hip like a hammer. He jerked — instinctive, immediate — and the pile *answered*.

The weight on his chest dropped half an inch, his body compressing under it like a sponge. Dust billowed into his mouth. The stone above his head scraped down hard against his forearm, and the muscles *screamed* — finally reaching their limit after holding for far too long.

And somewhere deep inside... something *snapped*.

He gasped — a full breath for the first time in minutes — and the sudden expansion made everything shift again. He shoved hard against the nearest stone, pressing his shoulder against it, kicking down to try and twist his hip away from the pressure. It wasn't a choice, but pure reflex. He couldn't help it. His body demanded oxygen. Demanded motion.

Demanded *freedom*.

"David — *stop!* You're making it worse!" Felix's voice cracked as stone shifted overhead.

But David wasn't listening. He was gone.

Every muscle seized in panic, heaving against the crush, desperate to escape. His thoughts blurred into static, a single command screaming louder than pain, louder than logic:

OUT.

His left arm tore free of its space, elbow crashing the side of the pile as he tried to lever his torso upward — sheer instinct, blind and useless. The stone he'd been holding off finally dropped, slamming down against his forehead with a brutal scrape, narrowly missing his eye.

The shift collapsed the fragile gap Dwight had carved out. The moment he felt the rush of air vanish, Dwight yanked his arm back with a sharp yell, stone rasping down his forearm and tearing a line through both skin and jacket in a single clean snag.

He stumbled back hard, clutching his wrist. "He's panicking!"

“David, *stop!* You have to calm down!” Felix snapped, already scrambling to find a grip on the nearest rock. “You’re going to bring it all down!”

David was beyond listening, the insistent cries of his teammates drowned out by the screaming in his own mind. He thrashed — not in any useful direction, not toward rescue — just against *everything*. His limbs struck out at pressure points, searching for a weakness in the crush, but found only more stone.

He wasn’t fighting them. He was fighting *everything*.

The dust clawing down his throat. The weight grinding in around his ribs. The dark. The silence. The sheer *wrongness* of his body being unable to move, to breathe, to *be*.

Cause and effect had left the building. Reason was gone. There was only movement now — fast, feral, unthinking. A primal spasm that flung his hips sideways, body twisting toward a space that didn’t exist, trying to *be elsewhere* by sheer force alone.

Above him, Felix barely caught a loose chunk before it tumbled. He flung it away, hand already grabbing at another.

“He’s going to destabilize everything,” he snapped. “Help me get this clear!”

Dwight scrambled back to the pile, skidding on grit, blood streaking down his arm.

“David, please—!”

For a moment, it looked like he might actually get free.

David’s shoulder shoved upward, scraping stone aside with a jagged screech. One slab near his head slipped loose, dragging a pale gouge in the rock as it rolled — and a gap opened.

Light. Air.

But then gravity remembered him again.

The rubble poured down, sweeping across the pile from the remains of the staircase above. A chunk near the top shifted, dislodging the stone above his left arm. It dropped — *hard* — pinning him sideways and dragging his arm down with it. Grit sprayed out in all directions as the weight surged. The weight dropped, slow but unrelenting, filling every open space.

The weight crushed inward, and David's chest folded beneath it. His ribs compressed, oxygen stolen before he could even try to reclaim it. His vision exploded into white — too tight, too loud, too *much* — and the world tipped sideways into silence.

"Felix, the center's falling!" Dwight shouted.

"I see it — brace that corner — *shit* — *David!*"

Another stone went flying as Dwight tore at the edge of the collapse. Dust plumed up, stinging his eyes. "David?! David, are you okay?"

Felix stepped hesitantly back from the rubble. He was scanning — eyes darting over the pile, cataloguing what had shifted, what progress had all been lost.

"Did you see where he moved? Is he—?"

"I... I don't know." Dwight's voice cracked. "The gap's gone. I can't tell if he shifted or—"

The words died in the stillness.

No voice answered.

Just the hush of settling dust... and the soft, steady grind of stone.

Ch 4 – Extraction

Dwight dove back into the rubble, tearing at loose stones with shaking hands. He tried for one of the heavier chunks, but his injured arm screamed in protest, the sharp throb in his wrist making it hard to lift, and the blood running down his palm left his grip weak and clumsy.

He was aiming for the same gap he'd carved out earlier — hoping, praying it hadn't fully collapsed. But the pile had shifted too far. Every reference point was gone. He was digging blind.

It wasn't until his third failed lift that he realized he was alone.

He glanced up, confused — and saw Felix a few feet back, standing stiffly in the dust. His eyes were locked on the rubble, unfocused and distant, his posture rigid. One hand still held a small chunk of sandstone he hadn't dropped. His fingers twitched around it absently, but the rest of him didn't move.

His chest rose and fell in quick, shallow bursts. Breathing too fast. Not blinking.

Felix wasn't frozen. He was *folding*. Quietly crumpling in on himself as the panic overtook him.

"Felix!" Dwight's voice cracked as he shouted across the rubble. "*Come on — get over here!*"

No reply.

Swearing under his breath, Dwight scrambled over, grabbing for Felix's arm — only to find it stiff, locked in place like it didn't belong to him. Up close, he could hear it: a soft murmur under Felix's breath, looping fragments of thought, barely audible over the rasp of his shallow breathing.

"It shouldn't have collapsed... I made the call... I should have seen it—"

His eyes weren't tracking. He wasn't blinking. Just staring through the pile like it was a grave he'd dug himself.

Dwight's stomach sank.

Felix wasn't just panicking. He was *gone*. Disassociating hard — caught in the guilt spiral, stuck in the feedback loop. If someone didn't break him out of it fast, he was going to shut down completely.

Panic flared — not at the rocks, but at *Felix*. At the distant stare, the static loop of words, the sinking posture. He'd seen it before. Survivors slipping inward. Folding in on themselves mid-trial, locked so deep inside they couldn't hear their name shouted right beside them. Between the mental spirals and whatever the Fog did to people to prolong pain, some of them didn't resurface for days.

With Jill outside keeping Nemesis busy, if he didn't do something fast, he was about to lose his only help.

Something sparked in the back of his mind. Something he had seen other survivors do in moments like this. It didn't always work, but...

Before he could think about it too much and potentially talk himself out of it, he did the only thing he'd ever seen bring someone else around in a hurry.

He slapped him. Hard.

The sound cracked through the rubble louder than it should've — knuckles against cheekbone, clean and sharp. Felix hit the ground with a startled grunt, blinking up at Dwight in confused alarm.

"Oh my god—oh my god I'm so *sorry*—I didn't mean to—shit—I just—*you weren't there*, I didn't know what to do—are you okay??"

Felix blinked again. Raised a hand to his cheek. "...Did you just *hit* me?"

"I panicked!" Dwight squeaked.

Felix stared at him for a second longer — then huffed a breath, somewhere between a laugh and a scoff.

Dwight crouched down, offering a hand. "I didn't mean to hit you that hard, I just... I needed help."

Felix took it, still half-stunned. "Help? Right, we were — *shit*, sorry... yeah, I'm ok."

The moment settled between them like dust, reorienting Felix back onto the pile as focus swept away whatever thoughts had tried to take him.

If Dwight could break out of it, so could he.

There was no time to dwell.

The pile had shifted too much — David's position could've been anywhere by now. What was once a half-buried incline off the staircase wall had slumped into something closer to a landslide: jagged, lopsided, and barely holding its shape. Each motion sent fine debris cascading across the surface like snow.

Felix and Dwight dove back in, tearing away anything unstable — grabbing whatever stones looked like they'd cause trouble and chucking them down the slope.

Dwight was working from memory, fingers bleeding from grit and broken edges, trying to trace the last place he'd touched David's hand. The gap he'd made was gone. Swallowed up in the collapse.

At least only the upper layers seemed to still be unstable, though. As he worked his way down, the larger stones seemed to have settled into something less chaotic, and could be worked around easily enough. It didn't take long for him to have tunneled partway into the pile itself, managing to get nearly half his torso in, piling smaller debris out and firing it behind him. David had been moving around a lot, but there was no way he had gotten that far from where he had been. If Dwight could re-open the area where he had last seen him, chances were good that he could find him again.

Digging his fingers in around a good-sized chunk and wiggling it free, he finally spotted a flash of red fabric

"I got him!" Dwight shouted. "I—I think I got him!"

He cleared a ragged channel around the shape of an arm — elbow half-bent, the length vanishing under the bulk of jacket. He followed it upward, hand dragging through loose gravel and crumbled plaster, until his fingers brushed against something solid.

Forehead. Cold and tacky with blood.

"Felix — here! I've got his head!"

Felix scrambled over, slipping on the slope. Together, they widened the gap, opening the small tunnel up to the outside air stone by stone, until David's face came into view.

Pale. Dust-caked. Blood seeping from his temple.

But there was a pulse.

It fluttered weakly beneath Dwight's fingers — thready, irregular, but definitely there.

Felix threw another stone off to the side, trying to sort out just how bad of an angle David was pinned at. Now that he had a better view, he could spot the edge of a much longer piece than the stones they had been digging at crossing over his collarbone. It seemed to be bracing the worst of the upper pile from digging too sharply into his torso, but there was no way to tell from here how far down it reached. For all he knew, David's legs could be absolute pulp further down, without this slab protecting them. Some of these stones were insanely heavy and sharp.

It was a good thing this larger piece had been preventing those sharp edges from cutting into vital organs. The slab would have taken all that weight and spread it out, instead of letting it stab straight down. Less of a battering and more...

Nudging Dwight to the side, Felix crouched to work a hand down along his collarbone, trying to get under the slab. The muscles under his hand were lightly flexing in shallow, sporadic bursts against the weight above. The pressure had been spread out over his entire chest, compressing him down against the sand with every piece that fell from above.

The geometry clicked.

That slab was at the bottom of the pile. It wasn't new to the collapse — it has been there from the start. Felix stared at David's half-buried body, heart thudding, brain kicking into gear. The compression hadn't just happened at the end — it had been building. For *minutes*, maybe longer. That stupid, *stupid man* hadn't said a word. He'd held it all in. Let it get worse. Let it *crush him* while they were trying to help.

Of course the panic had hit. Of *course* he had snapped. *Anyone* would have after that long.

"You absolute idiot," Felix hissed, shoving himself to his feet. He had to get that weight up and off David's chest. He needed something sturdy. Anything. He spun in place for a moment, doing a rapid inventory of the area around him and coming up empty.

His eyes paused on a nearby doorway, catching a flash of movement as Jill lead Nemesis on a wild goose chase in the distance, before refocusing much closer, a spark of an idea forming.

"Keep clearing what you can," he barked to Dwight. "I'll be right back."

He sprinted for the edge of the Eyrie, boots skidding on broken rubble as he bolted out into the courtyard. His eyes locked onto the small ring of rusted iron fencing around one of the grave plots — nonsensical little monuments the Entity had scattered like décor. They looked sturdy; hopefully it would be enough.

He crashed into the closest post, gripped the bars, and *wrenched*. They didn't give easily. But he didn't stop. Anger fueled him. At David. At himself. At the Entity. At the *design* of this entire place.

With a shout and a final kick, a chunk of the wrought iron fencing snapped free with a pained squeal.

Felix turned and ran — twisted metal gripped like a weapon — back into the dark.

Dwight had stopped trying to clear the top of the pile. Too unstable. Every time he shifted something, it felt like the rest of it wanted to come with.

Instead, he'd gone back into his small tunnel, and set himself to widening it. Probably not the smartest idea he had all day, he mused, but they needed to get some kind of space around him and the top kept shifting around too damned much. Maybe from down here, Dwight could get some of the pressure off him so he could breathe easier.

He had noted Felix's unspoken concern almost immediately, and had double checked for himself. David was *technically* still breathing, if you could call it that. Small, insufficient wisps at far too high of a speed didn't really instill confidence. But at least David was still trying.

Dwight dug his way around the shallower end of the pile, working down past David's left arm — thankfully not pinned under him — and opening a gap around his side. Thanks to the slab above, he had a nearly clear line down both sides of David's torso, but couldn't get much of the weight off without making the upper layers shift threateningly.

He followed along the fabric of David's jacket hem, sweeping away more debris and trying to get at the stones around the large piece pinning his torso in place. Every one that he managed to shift sent small streams of grit raining down around him, making him question every move. He didn't really feel much like being buried alongside David.

Outside the rubble, he could hear Felix storming back in, already calling on him to get out of the way.

"Shift! Give me space — I don't want to accidentally hit you!"

"Hit me? What are you —"

"Get *out*! Just *MOVE*."

Dwight barely managed to push himself backwards along his cramped tunnel before a chunk of metal speared through the space between a few stones. He yelped and yanked his arm out of the way, scampering out of the gap to see Felix trying to pry the stones up with what looked like a busted piece of fencing.

He angled the fence piece, one end digging into the rubble while the other rested across a larger chunk. There wasn't a lot of room to maneuver, and he had to reposition twice

to keep from *spearing* David in the process before finally managing to settle it along the stones just above the slab. Trying to get under it would guarantee that he would stab David by accident. This way, at least he could get some of the weight off the compression layer. Possibly even enough to pull him loose entirely.

“Alright.” He nodded. “When I say go, I need you to put *everything* on it. Don’t pull — *press*. Get as much weight behind it as you can.”

Dwight looked dubious. “You realize I have the upper body strength of wet spaghetti, right?”

“You don’t need it. Just put your weight into it. It doesn’t need to move much. I’d do it but I’ve seen you favoring that arm. You’re not going to be able to pull him free.”

Dwight winced a bit, flexing against the throb in his arm, but nodded and moved to brace himself against the bar. Felix took his place at the gap he had carved out, easily slipping between the stones before calling out for him to start shoving.

He leaned his whole weight into the bar — back bowed, knees shaking, blood dripping from his elbow — and couldn’t help but grin a bit as he felt something on the other side give way.

Just a few inches. But it was *something*.

Felix dove further into the pocket of space, immediately scraping aside whatever rubble remained over David’s chest and arm. Not all of it. There wasn’t room. But he could *move*. He could *touch*. He could see the stuttering rise and fall of David’s ribs. Hear the dry rasp of breath in his throat. It didn’t sound healthy, or even stable for that matter, but it was more than it had been.

It would have to be enough.

Between the two of them, they managed it.

The slab lifted just enough — Dwight grunting, legs shaking, throwing everything he had into the bar — and Felix got an arm under David’s shoulders and *pulled*. The pressure gave with a low, grinding groan. As soon as the weight shifted, the rest of the stones seemed to settle on their own, collapsing inward to fill the space he left behind.

A few sharp edges scraped his legs on the way out. Ripped cloth. Skin. Nothing critical. Nothing a simple medkit couldn’t fix. He had gotten lucky in that aspect, the rubble

along his legs having been no worse off for him than a hook injury. Probably less so. Even then, it didn't matter.

They had him.

Felix dragged David clear, huffing from the exertion as he laid him out on the flat stone behind them. Dwight dropped the bar and scrambled over, falling to his knees beside them.

"David—? Come on, man — talk to me—"

He reached out and shook his shoulder — gently, but desperate — and the stillness was deafening. "Is he —? "

"Pulse is still there. He's just not breathing right." Felix set to easing David's shoulders up to rest along his lap. He tipped his head back carefully, opening his airway the way he'd seen medics do, the extra space granting a light wheeze from him as his eyelids fluttered lightly.

"There you go," Felix muttered, brushing dust from his face. "You're not allowed to check out on me now."

Dwight let out a strained huff as he hovered nearby, clearly not sure how to be of help. He looked down at David's arm, bits of skin visible through the torn sleeve of his jacket. The damage was clear. Bruises were already forming in lurid shades of red and violet, crawling up from the wrist to the shoulder in uneven splotches. It didn't *look* broken, but that arm was going to scream when it finally woke back up.

Maybe it was better that he was still out.

"I don't understand why this keeps happening. It was never like this..."

"I thought you guys were always fighting to not die in these trials?"

"Not like this!" Dwight stared at David, trying to will him to wake up. "There was structure. Ritual. Patterns. You're too new to the Fog; you wouldn't know. But this kind of shit? This *never* happened. I don't know what to DO anymore."

"Think maybe punching him will help too?"

Dwight flinched, a light flush blooming across his face. "I *said* I was sorry —"

Felix flashed him a quick smirk, betraying the attempt at defusing the tension, and Dwight visibly uncoiled a bit.

“This is all so screwed up now. I didn’t know what else to do...”

“No, you made the right call.” Felix ran a hand over David’s chest, frowning at the uneven, shallow movements, the edges of a thought pressing in on his mind.

“Although... it might not be the worst idea...”

“You want me to hit him? Are you out of your mind?”

“No, I mean... hang on.”

Felix shifted his grip and pressed two fingers into the muscle just above David’s injured shoulder, digging straight into the bruising that mottled whatever skin was visible.

David jerked like he’d been shocked — a raw, hoarse inhale tearing out of him with the pain. His chest hitched violently against it, the air locked behind tightly clenched muscles for a moment, before finally breaking free with an ugly ragged sound.

A second wet gasp tore out of him like his body didn’t *want* to breathe but couldn’t stop trying. Another followed, then a third — until the motion collapsed into a raw, hacking cough that curled him hard onto his side and out of Felix’s grip.

His lungs were *fighting* the return. Like they’d forgotten what breathing felt like and were relearning by force. Each inhale was a frantic jerk, each exhale a failed sob. He choked on air like it was water, body spasming from the effort.

Felix muttered something in a language Dwight couldn’t quite catch as he knelt beside David, one hand braced lightly against his back, rubbing slow circles in an attempt to ease the shaking. It wasn’t much, but it helped steady the worst of the spasms. David was curled in on himself, breaths still ragged, but the panic was bleeding off. Slowly. Painfully. Like steam venting from a pressure valve.

Dwight sank back on his heels, finally letting the tension leave his shoulders. His hands were trembling — still streaked with dust and blood — and he balled them tightly against his lap trying to steady himself.

Felix reached for his neck, fingers searching for his pulse — and David flinched hard, jerking back with a hitched breath as his eyes flew open. Alarm flickered there for a split

second, chased quickly by confusion... then heat. Embarrassed fury, sharp and defensive.

He shoved Felix's hand away with a clumsy swat, the effort barely coordinated. "'m fine," he wheezed — the words cracked, shredded, broken in half by another coughing fit.

His body twitched as he dragged in a breath, followed by another, each one a battle. Still, he braced a hand beneath himself, stubborn to a fault, trying to push upright even as his whole frame trembled from the strain.

Felix didn't even wait for him to finish coughing before the fury hit.

"You idiot," he snapped, voice tight and sharp with leftover panic. "*How long* were you having trouble breathing in there? Why didn't you say anything?! I would have changed the entire approach! You damn near got yourself *killed*! What the hell were you thinking?!"

David, still catching up to the reality of being *not dead*, didn't flinch. His legs shook under him, right arm cradled close, but his jaw locked stubbornly as he shoved himself up another inch.

"We don't have time for this," he growled, eyes lit with a glare so sharp it looked like he planned to punch the Fog itself into submission. He staggered to his feet like a man with something to prove, wobbly legs carrying him limping towards the nearest doorway.

Dwight scrambled to steady him, reaching an arm out — but David batted him away, stubbornly dragging one foot past the other in a crooked shuffle toward the edge of the Eyrie.

"*Unbelievable*," Dwight muttered, half to himself. Watching the man push forward on half a lung, a jacked-up arm, and the raw fuel of unprocessed rage, he couldn't help the breathless laugh that broke loose. "Stubbornness and pure spite. That's all he's running on."

The universe seemed to agree.

As if on cue, David's eyes rolled back mid-step, knees buckling, his body finally cashing the debt his bravado had racked up. Dwight caught him just in time, locking his good arm around David's shoulders. "Whoa — gotcha, gotcha—!"

Felix moved in without a word, and together they got him back onto the sand, David groaning and muttering curses as they lowered him. He tried to fight it, but even the fight had gone soft now—just slurred protest and shallow breath.

He was done.

Felix leaned in close, his voice low, taut with fury still burning under the relief. “*Stay down*, idiot. Don’t you *ever* do that to me again. Do you hear me?” His hands were firm against David’s shoulders, grounding and unrelenting. “You think you’re invincible, but I damn near just watched you *die*. I am not doing that again.”

David blinked up at him, bleary and barely present. The words hit somewhere behind his eyes, too close and too loud, but he didn’t have the strength to push them away.

The last thing he heard before the black overtook him was Felix’s voice — sharp, scolding, and laced with something bitter underneath that bloomed a fuzzy sense of guilt somewhere in the back of his mind.

Ch 5 – Fallout

The fire crackled low, casting warped shadows against the crumbling stone around camp. Soft amber light edged the survivors in flickers of warmth—on cloth, on skin, on all the things they weren’t saying.

Dwight sat with his back to one of the ruined archways, his arm cradled in a makeshift sling — someone’s spare flannel, frayed at the edges. Not pain, exactly. What ache had survived the trip through the Fog had since settled into a dull stiffness that made every motion feel like a negotiation.

Jill crouched by the fire, half-watching the embers, half-glaring at the others like she couldn’t decide whether to scold them or just throw a stick and call it even.

"I leave for *one* trial," she muttered, breaking the silence. "And you clowns manage to trigger a cave-in? What the hell even happened in there?"

Dwight opened his mouth. Closed it again. Thought better of the whole idea. The tension was high enough, and he didn’t feel like having it turn against him.

The fire held its breath. Crackled, but barely. Its glow pushed shadows into the corners of the old stone ring, gilding faces that weren't looking at each other, only at the flicker between them.

Across the flames, Felix sat on the bare stone — not quite hunched, but folded tight. Hands limp in his lap. Legs pulled in close. Coiled, like movement would be too much. Like stillness was the only way to stop everything from slipping sideways.

The firelight glinted off his face in brief, uneven flashes — too bright, too sharp.

His gaze stayed fixed on the flames, but there was nothing soft about it. Quiet fury, bottled perfectly behind his eyes.

David sat opposite him. Slouched, smaller than usual, shoulders drawn in like a man trying to disappear into the earth one vertebra at a time.

His jacket was off, tossed somewhere behind him. Shirt sleeves shoved up to the elbows, exposing the bruises that tracked his arm in raw, splotchy streaks — violet and wine-dark, angry even in the Fog's forgiving light.

He'd barely said two words since his second impromptu nap. Claudette had checked his ribs with gentle fingers. Meg had given him a mug of something warm and vaguely sweet. Someone — he couldn't even remember who — had wrapped a blanket around his shoulders like a cape he didn't ask for.

Now and then, his eyes flicked toward Felix — never long, never steady. A glance. A ghost of a look. Then back down. Like if he met those eyes for real, something might fracture beyond repair.

The silence wasn't just awkward. It was dense. Suspended.

Like the Fog itself was watching, waiting to see who would break first.

No one spoke.

Even Jill — who could usually be counted on to cut tension with a well-placed snort or tactical sarcasm — had gone still. Her earlier irritation had banked into silence, burning low like the coals.

But her eyes kept straying to Felix. Not worried. Not exactly. Just... tracking. He only looked calm to someone that wasn't familiar with quite rage, and she was waiting to see if the fault line in him would hold.

The longer the silence went on for, the heavier it felt. It settled between them — dense, restless. Lacking in the peace that should have come with healing wounds and building fatigue. Thick enough that it felt like a fifth presence in the circle, sitting between them with smoke on its breath.

Unable to stand the tension, David shifted. He set the mug down beside him with a soft ceramic clink, fingers lingering around it like maybe, *if he was lucky*, it would swallow him whole.

He stared at the fire. Then the cup. Then the dirt.

Finally, cautiously, like he had to test the air first — he cleared his throat.

"...You gonna yell at me again?"

Felix didn't look over. Didn't blink.

"No," he said softly, firelight catching on the leftover dust that still coated his hair.

"I got it out of my system."

A pause.

"...You sure?"

"No."

David tried to take a deeper breath to steady himself — he regretted it immediately. His ribs flared under the bruises, a deep ache that echoed through his torso. He winced lightly against the sensation, shifting his pose the smallest amount to take the excess pressure off.

The next trial was going to suck if he couldn't even take a deep breath without folding in half. That was, assuming Felix didn't just cripple him before the night was done. Not that he wouldn't have deserved it.

Felix glanced over, the motion subtle but sharp. His expression was unreadable, carved into something just shy of composed. A careful arrangement of clear restraint — like someone trying very hard not to say something they'd regret.

"I'm not mad you got hurt," His voice didn't rise. Didn't waver. "I'm mad you hid it. *From me.*"

That landed.

Not just as a reprimand — there was a strong tone of betrayal under it. David's gaze dropped instantly, back to the fire, like maybe if he stared hard enough the flames would explain what the hell he was supposed to say.

"...Didn't think it mattered," he muttered, after too long.

Felix's jaw flexed — just once.

Quiet. Controlled.

Just enough to say: *wrong answer.*

"I didn't want you two to panic," David said, softer now. His voice scraped low, like it was trying not to shake. "Didn't think it'd help if I made it a thing. Figured... if I kept quiet, we'd all get through it faster. You guys didn't need the extra stress in the moment."

He hesitated, then added — too quiet:

"Didn't think anyone would notice if I just didn't say anything."

He had meant it as a shield. A half-hearted excuse, a clumsy patch on the crawlspace he'd built to hide the worst of it.

It landed more like a door slamming shut.

Felix turned his head — slow, sharp, deliberate.

“Do you think I wouldn’t have eventually noticed?” he asked, the firelight caught in his eyes, gleaming through the crack in his voice.

“You seriously think I wouldn’t care?”

David flinched internally. Not from pain — that, at least, had dulled to a manageable throb under the Fog’s numb haze.

But *that*? That low, even voice from Felix — no raised tone, no sarcasm, just open truth dropped on him like a stone. That hurt something deep in his chest that flared worse than the damage to his ribs had.

“It’s not that,” David said quickly, *too* quickly. The words spilled like he was trying to plug the hole with excuses.

Felix didn’t interrupt. Didn’t argue. Didn’t *save him* from the silence that followed.

Somehow, *that* was worse.

David raked a hand back through his hair, fingers catching in dried blood along the way and twitching lightly against the pull, like the sting was deserved.

“I’ve always handled my shit,” he muttered. “That’s what I *do*.”

His voice hardened, not in anger, but defense. Old habits surfacing like bruises under skin.

“People don’t need to babysit me. They need me solid. If I fall apart — what the fuck happens to the rest of you?”

It was a deflection. A wall built out of duty. It sounded flimsy even as he had said it.

“And what happens if you die?”

Quiet. Even.

“You think that won’t break something?”

David didn’t answer. He couldn’t. Because suddenly, *he wasn’t sure*.

The silence stretched again — not empty this time, but taut. Like a wire pulled too tight between two bodies while everyone else was pretending they couldn’t hear it hum.

Jill nudged a stick in the fire with the toe of her boot. She watched the sparks jump like it was the most fascinating thing she’d seen all day. Anything to keep her eyes off *them*.

Dwight, on the other side of the circle, was rewrapping the same strip of cloth around his arm for the third time. Not because it needed fixing. Because it gave his hands something to do. Because stillness felt *dangerous*.

Neither of them spoke. Neither dared to. Not while the fallout was still settling.

Not while whatever thread tethered Felix and David to each other was straining like that — so close to snapping it felt like the fire should’ve gone out from the pressure alone.

Felix’s voice broke the silence, flat and quiet.

“You would have been brought back.”

David looked up at that — mouth parting, maybe to protest, maybe to argue. Felix didn’t let him, raising a hand to cut off his reply.

“But not *all* of you.”

The words were *precise*. Surgical in their restraint. Carefully chosen.

David stared at him. Felix’s eyes didn’t meet his this time. They drifted toward the fire — like whatever he was about to say was easier to aim at the flames.

“You know what happens,” he said. “They come back, sure. But they don’t always remember. They forget names. Details. Whole *people*.”

His voice didn’t shake. But something in it cracked — as if it had to be said before it turned to ash in his throat.

“I’ve watched it happen,” Felix said, his voice softer now. Thinner.

“I’ve watched someone stare straight through their own teammate like they were a stranger. Because the Fog *took* that thread from them. And it *never* came back.”

David swallowed. Hard. His throat felt tight, raw — The words somehow lodging there instead of landing clean.

Felix looked at him then. Really looked. Not through the fire. Not past him. At him.

His eyes were sharp, but there was something exposed there too — something he wasn’t used to letting show.

“If you’d died today,” he said quietly, “And I had to sit across from you tomorrow while you acted like we’d never even met—”

He stopped.

Didn’t finish.

Didn’t need to.

The thought hung there, complete on its own.

David felt the burn settle low in his gut. This had never been about the injury at all. This had been about *loss* for Felix. Not the kind that the survivors were used to — bleeding, screaming, that moment of panic before getting brought back — but the kind that *erases*.

There was a sudden pressure behind David’s ribs — something inside that had cracked open and didn’t know how to close again. Too wide. Too raw. A guilt that filled every available space. His hands moved without aim — one pressing instinctively to his injured arm, the other twisting in his lap like it was trying to find something to hold on to.

He fixed his gaze on the fire again, too uncomfortable to keep facing Felix. The man's anger at him had hurt before, sure, but now it hurt in a way that *mattered*. He didn't know what to do with that.

His voice came out small and bare. Fragile in a way none of them were used to hearing from him.

"I figured... worst case, I'd reset. Take the hit. Come back fresh."

He swallowed, the firelight highlighting the shame that flushed up the sides of his neck.

"I didn't think anyone would—"

He stopped himself.

Breathed.

Tried again.

"I didn't mean to scare you."

It wasn't eloquent. Wasn't grand. But at least it was honest, even if it hurt just to say it.

David finally glanced up — a flick of the eyes, barely enough to register, but full of a silent, desperate wish that something in Felix's expression would have softened by now. That this could be over. That the worst had already passed.

He wasn't that lucky.

Felix's face hadn't changed. There was no rage. No heat. Just the weight of disappointment. And that was somehow *worse*.

"You didn't just scare me," His voice calm, matter of fact, "You *almost erased yourself*."

David, who had thrown himself in front of killers, taken hits without flinching, bled out beneath hooks and crawlspaces and basement stairs — who thought he knew what damage felt like — had no armor for that.

He gaze wilted back down into the fire. And for the first time since they'd pulled him out of the rubble,

he felt like maybe he hadn't actually made it out at all.

The silence that followed could've been carved with a knife.

Even the fire seemed to crackle more quietly now—its usual hisses and pops reduced to something hesitant, like it was trying not to intrude.

David looked ready to dissolve into the stone beneath him.

Felix was still watching, still unreadable — eyes narrowed, posture tight, like he hadn't decided if this counted as closure or just damage control.

CRACK

The fire split open with a sudden snap as a log shifted. The sound rang longer than it should have, snapping through the quiet like a warning shot.

Dwight jumped so hard he nearly dropped the marshmallow stick he hadn't actually used in the last twenty minutes.

It clattered against the stone, and he fumbled to pick it up like it mattered.

Jill, who had been studiously examining a patch of gravel like it held the secrets to the universe, finally cleared her throat.

“Well,” she said lightly, a forced cheer pushing through the awkward tension, “remind me never to leave you boys unsupervised again.”

Felix blinked and startled slightly, like he’d forgotten anyone else was there.

David exhaled, shoulders slumping. Tension bleeding out like someone had finally released the pressure valve around his lungs.

“You miss all the fun, Jill,” Dwight muttered, forcing a grin. “You *chose* to run Nemesis around for half the trial.”

“Well, *someone* needed to.” Jill tossed a pebble at his boot. “If I’d known you were gonna start a landslide while I was out playing fetch with Frankenstein, I’d have brought snacks.”

Felix let out a quiet huff. Possibly a laugh. Possibly a sound of exhausted despair. Hard to say.

David just scrubbed both hands over his face, like he wanted to erase the last ten minutes from

existence by sheer force of will.

Jill gave him a sideways look.

“And you.”

She pointed at him with the same tone she used to use to threaten her former coworkers.

“Next time you decide to die mid-trial and not tell anyone, I’m sedating you with a tranquilizer and dragging your ass back by your ankles.”

To one side, Dwight full-on *snorted*. David groaned into his hands, wishing he could be *anywhere* else. This constant piercing attention was wearing him down. Though the sarcasm and over the top empty threats were a nice relief from the weight of the earlier tension.

And just like that, the air lightened. The tension didn't vanish, but it shifted. Relented.

Turned into something livable.

The wound still ached. But it felt like it could start to heal now.

The fire had settled into a low, steady crackle.

Jill leaned back against the log with the smug look of a woman who knew exactly how to break up a fistfight without lifting a finger.

Dwight had taken up poking half-heartedly at the flames with a twig, still trying to process everything, a light grin ghosting across his expression.

And David... David just sat there.

Shoulders low. Head bowed. One arm curled tight against his ribs, the bruising hidden under his shirt.

Felix shifted in place — his posture opening up, less tense now, though his brows still hadn't fully smoothed.

"You really scared me," No bite. No edge. Disappointed irritation finally worn down to something softer.

David nodded once. "Yeah... I didn't mean to."

"I know."

Felix exhaled like he'd been holding it all night. "I thought you trusted me."

David's hand curled a little tighter over his ribs.

"I do," he murmured. "I just... I'm not used to being the one who needs watching."

Felix hummed — somewhere between a sigh and a tired laugh.

"Yeah, well. Maybe get used to it."

David looked over at that — finally meeting Felix's eyes. The pride and bravado he wore like armor softened into something quieter.

Gratitude.

"...You did good," he murmured.

"Back there. Getting me out."

Felix shrugged, looking away before the moment could settle too deep.

"Didn't feel like dragging your corpse back to camp, that's all."

He nudged a twig with his boot. "You're heavy."

David huffed, the edge of a laugh pulling at his bruised ribs. "Wow. Thanks for the concern."

"Anytime."

They sat like that for a while — a tired calm, no longer on edge.

A peace truce forged from bruises and barely avoided catastrophe.

The fire popped.

The night moved on.

And maybe — just maybe —

the bond between them had settled into something a little more solid.

